Shrestha hinted at a very important dimension to Nepal's 'people's war' apart from general disappointment at the widespread corruption, social and political instability, bickering politicians, and abuse of power instead of expected economic progress and greater equality that had come in the wake of the 1990 uprising: Nepal's intricate caste system and diverse ethnic composition. The vast majority of Maoist fighters came from the lower castes and the so-called 'backward' ethnic groups such as the hill-dwelling Mongol Magars and the Tharus in the narrow valleys closer to the lowlands. The arrival of the Maoists and their 'proletarian ideology' gave lower castes and tribes authority and power over the higher castes such as the *bahuns* (the local term for Brahmins), and the *chhetris* (Kshatriyas), the Indo-Aryan upper strata of society, which traditionally had treated them as second class citizens or worse. In the case of many of the Maoist foot soldiers, this explains why a seemingly anachronistic movement made such headway. The country needed a social revolution, and, for many, the CPN-M appealed as the only alternative to the old, repressive order.

Even Prachanda wrote in an assessment of the first two years of the war that

> Along with the development of the People's War a new consciousness for fighting for their own rights is spreading amongst many oppressed nationalities of the country such as the Magars, Gurungs, Tamangs, Newars, Tharus, Rais, Limbus and Madhesis…Similarly…a wave of organisation and struggle has been created among *Dalit* castes [low caste people] at a greater speed and wider scale. The *Dalits* are today rebelling against inhuman tyranny perpetrated upon them by the feudal state of high caste Hindus.[10]

But many of the leaders of the CPN-M, including Prachanda and Bhattarai, were actually bahun intellectuals. This is again a striking parallel with the Shining Path, whose leader, Guzmán, was a well-educated former professor of philosophy, while his followers were mostly poor people belonging to indigenous tribes of non-European descent. In the same vein, the dreaded, and likewise Maoist, Khmer Rouge in Cambodia was led by French-educated intellectuals whose foot soldiers, poor peasants from the countryside, were motivated by hatred of the better-off people in the cities rather than by ideology.

Prachanda was born in a village in Kaski district in 1954, the son of a farmer, but still a bahun. The would-be revolutionary received a diploma in science in agriculture from the Institute of Agriculture and Animal Science in Rampur in southern Nepal. Ironically, he was once employed by the